
Topic ► Introduction to 1 Communication

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this topic, you should be able to:

1. Explain what is meant by the word “communication” in general;
2. Identify the main elements in the communication process;
3. Differentiate between oral and written communication;
4. Highlight some basic tips on writing; and
5. List the common pitfalls to avoid in written communication.

► INTRODUCTION

This topic gives you an overview of communication and introduces you to the main elements in the communication process. It also highlights the importance of writing clear, positive messages and offers you some basic tips and guidelines on this form of communication so that you may become more proficient in the kind of writing needed at home as well as in the college and workplace. You will also learn about some of the common pitfalls which may impede the effectiveness of written communication.

1.1

WHAT IS COMMUNICATION?

Communication is a learned skill. However, while most people are born with the physical ability to talk, not all can communicate well unless they make special efforts to develop and refine this skill further. Very often, we take the ease with which we communicate with each other for granted, so much so that we sometimes forget how complex the communication process actually is.

1.1.1 Elements in Communication

Have you ever wondered why some people can communicate so well while others fail to get their message across? What are the elements that must be present in the communication process before it can be successful and effective?

Well, communication has been defined as the act of giving, receiving or exchanging information, ideas and opinions so that the “message” is completely understood by both parties. Look at Figure 1.1 below. The illustration shows clearly that in a communication process, there must be a sender who speaks or sends a message, and a receiver who listens or receives the message.

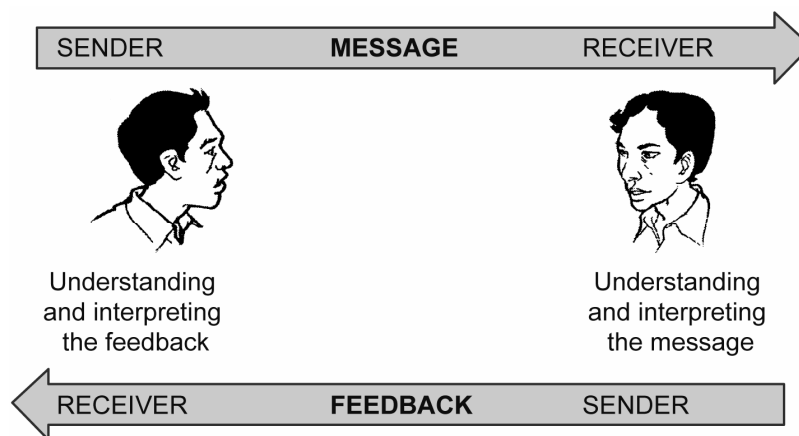


Figure 1.1: The communication process

The sender sends a message with a certain intention in mind. The receiver of the message tries to understand and interpret the message sent. He then gives feedback to the original sender, who in turn interprets the feedback. This process, repeated continuously, constitutes communication.

Clearly, there are several major elements in the communication process – a sender, message, channel, receiver, feedback, context. There is both a **speaker’s intention** to convey a message and a **listener’s reception** of what has been said. Thus, listening skills are just as important as speaking skills in order for communication to be effective.

This means that if you want to get your message across accurately, you need to consider these three things:

- The message;
- The audience or receiver; and
- How the message is likely to be received.

A message is only considered successfully communicated when both the sender and the receiver perceive and understand it in the same way. If this does not happen, then there may be a breakdown in communication, which may ultimately stand in the way of you realising your goals, either personally or professionally.



ACTIVITY 1.1

The meaning of communication lies in the way that it is received.

Do you agree with the above statement? Discuss with your friends during the next tutorial session.

1.1.2 Factors Affecting Communication

As mentioned earlier, effective communication is a two-way process but there are a number of factors which may disrupt this process and affect the overall interpretation and understanding of what was communicated. Myriad problems can pop up at different stages of the communication process. These can relate to any of the elements involved – the sender, message, channel, receiver, feedback and context. It is therefore important to understand some of the factors that affect communication so that you can try to get your message across with minimal misunderstanding and confusion.

Below are some possible problem areas that may turn out to be barriers to effective communication:

(a) **Status/Role**

The sender and receiver of a message may be of equal status within a hierarchy (e.g. managers in an organisation) or they may be at different levels (e.g. manager/employee, lecturer/student, business owner/clients). This difference in status sometimes affects the effectiveness of the communication process.

(b) **Cultural Differences**

Cultural differences, both within or outside the organisation (for example, inter-departmental dealings and communication with outside organisations or ethnic minorities) may impede the communication process.

(c) **Choice of Communication Channels**

Before you choose your communication channel, you should ask yourself whether the channel is appropriate for a particular purpose and the person/receiver you have in mind. Sending messages via inappropriate channels can send out wrong signals and end up creating confusion.

(d) **Length of Communication**

The length of the message also affects the communication process. You need to be sure that it serves the purpose and is appropriate for the receiver. Is the message too long or too brief?

(e) **Use of Language**

Poor choice of words or weak sentence structure also hampers communication. The same goes for inappropriate punctuation. The two sentences below illustrate clearly how different placement of punctuation can change the entire meaning of a sentence:

*Woman, without her, man is nothing.
Woman, without her man, is nothing.*

(f) **Disabilities**

Disabilities such as impaired sight, dyslexia and poor mental health can also be barriers to good communication, and should be taken into consideration when evaluating the effectiveness of the communication process. You may need to use hearing aids, sign language, magnifying systems, and symbols to alleviate problems caused by disabilities.

(g) **Known or Unknown Receiver**

Whether the receiver is known or unknown to you also plays a major role in determining the effectiveness of your communication. A known receiver may be better able to understand your message despite having insufficient information as both of you probably have common experiences and a shared schemata. An unknown receiver, on the other hand, may require more information and time to decode the message.

(h) **Individual Perceptions/Attitudes/Personalities**

Sometimes, the method of communication needs to take into consideration the receiver's personality traits, age and preferred style. The elderly and children, for example, have different communication needs and preferences when compared to young adults. Is the receiver of your message a visual, auditory, or kinesthetic sort of person? How do you think they will react to your message? Can you adapt your communication style to suit theirs?

- (i) **Atmosphere/Noise/Distracton**
Our surroundings can sometimes pose as barriers to effective communication. A noisy place (a party, for instance) usually puts a strain on oral communication as both the sender and the receiver need to put extra effort to get the message across and ensure that it is understood clearly and correctly.
- (j) **Clarity of Message**
Is the message conveyed in a clear or ambiguous manner?
- (k) **Lack of Feedback**
Feedback is important as it enables confirmation of understanding to be made by both parties. The lack of feedback can sometimes create problems as it can lead to uncertainty and confusion.



ACTIVITY 1.2

Your father is not keen on your decision to study medicine in the United Kingdom. How can you persuade him, bearing in mind the barriers to communication that you might encounter?

When choosing the most appropriate channel of communication, you should heed the following:

- (a) Consider all aspects of the communication process (interpretation, understanding, feedback).
- (b) Think carefully about possible barriers.
- (c) Evaluate the complexity of the message and decide how it might be best conveyed.
- (d) Ask yourself these questions:
 - Who? – Characteristics of the receiver(s).
 - Why? – Purpose of the communication.
 - What? – Content of the message.
 - How? – Oral, written, visual or a combination of all three.
 - Where? – Location of the meeting.
 - When? – Timing/time limit/expected response time.

- (e) Determine whether you are meeting or writing to the people concerned. Is the communication via face-to-face interaction, telephone, letter, e-mail, memo or a report?
- (f) Decisions about the most appropriate channel of communication also depend on factors such as cost, time, confidentiality, convention, urgency and whether written documentation is required.

1.2 DEFINING WRITTEN COMMUNICATION

As mentioned earlier, communication can be oral or in written form. What is the difference between these two main types of communication?

Oral communication involves conveying ideas, thoughts or information via a spoken language. In written communication, however, information is exchanged using written symbols, that is, via words and sentences. Written communication is the sharing and exchanging of written symbols between individuals or groups. It is also the presentation of ideas in a coherent manner in written form.

Written communication can take place via:

- Letters;
- Faxes;
- Email;
- Reports;
- Memos; and
- Advertisements.

You can acquire good writing skills through extensive reading, note-taking and listening. In order to communicate effectively via writing, you need to have a sound grounding in grammar and vocabulary so that you can present ideas, together with supporting details, in a unified and coherent manner.

1.3 WHY WRITTEN COMMUNICATION?

The next question that arises is: “Why do we need to communicate in written form? Why is there a need to document our work or keep written records?” The answers to these questions are many and varied.

For one thing, once you put something into writing, the message is there for posterity, so that others can read it again and again, whenever they like. This is

especially useful for research purposes where you need to build up on existing pools of knowledge.

Writing also means that information can be stored and transferred from individual to individual and group to group without relying on memory. Through the written word, records can exist independently of the writer.

The written document also helps you to keep abreast of development in whatever project you are involved in as it provides an avenue not only for the sharing of ideas or opinions, but also for the presenting and defending of viewpoints.

Written communication can also serve as a form of acknowledgement – proof that something has been done in case verification is needed later.

Sometimes, documenting work helps to clarify thoughts and thinking processes as it allows you to mull over things slowly, at your own pace. It is “thinking made public”.

So, what must be documented? Any idea, logic, argument or phraseology derived from an outside source must be documented. In academic writing, you must give credit for all borrowed materials, for example, quotations, references, information from primary and secondary sources, facts, data, statistics, opinions, ideas and interpretations which you have gathered from your reading and research.

Such material must be acknowledged and cited, irrespective of whether you have paraphrased, summarised or quoted directly. The only exception is what is loosely termed “general knowledge” or “common knowledge”, which is information or ideas generally known and accepted by everyone, including the writer and the audience.

You must cite and document all ideas and arguments borrowed from an outside source.



ACTIVITY 1.3

Why do you think formal work should always be documented?